

ON TECHNIQUE

Musical cryptograms

A musical cryptogram is a theme that uses the letter names for notes in order to encode a word, most often a person's name. Various devices give letters other than A to G—in German the letter “H” indicates B natural and E flat can be “Es” or “S”.

First used by Baroque composers, this technique was taken much further by Schumann. In his *Carnaval*, for example, a recurrent theme (A, E flat, C, B) spells the word “Asch,” the name of the town in which his betrothed, Ernestine von Fricken, was born. Schumann is represented by the notes E flat, C, B, A—spelling the abbreviation “Scha.”

“What would I not do **for love of you**, my own **Clara!**”

ROBERT SCHUMANN, LETTER TO CLARA WIECK, 1838

Romantic complications

In Schumann's personal life, a long, romantic attachment to an older woman was followed in 1834 by his betrothal to Ernestine von Fricken, whom he believed to be the daughter of a wealthy nobleman. He ended the engagement after discovering that she was illegitimate and penniless. This left him free to fall in love with Clara Wieck. His feelings for her probably informed the passionate piano solo *Fantasie*